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My Ethical Construct

U.S. educational institutions are currently undergoing a significant transformation in policy perspectives regarding public education, marking a fundamental shift in the relationship between policy and institutional practices (Elmore, 2000). This transformation indicates that school administrators are being compelled to take on responsibilities for which they are often inadequately prepared, with serious risks and consequences for all involved should they fail to meet these obligations. Additionally, it highlights the need for school administrators to reassess the role of institutional ethics and analyze the factors contributing to the gap between ethical behavior and their leadership responsibilities. The concept of ethical behavior is crucial for understanding the moral framework within which school administrators operate. It is shaped by personal values, experiences, and the broader environment in which individuals work and live. A strong grasp of ethics enables one to distinguish right from wrong conduct. Consequently, an administrator can apply their foundational ethics and moral principles in their leadership approach. For these reasons, I will begin my reflection by sharing my thoughts on my personal ethics and leadership behaviors.

My definition of ethics is a set of moral standards that uphold ethical practice in one's own life, home, workplace, and community. It is a framework that guides ethical decision-making, and each person has a different set of ethical standards. As Rebores (2001, p. 20) points out, ethical norms are determined by what is ethically good, experience, character of humanity and the world, and

principle of proportionality. I believe this guide helps people as they seek their own ethical system.

There are two traditional approaches to the study of normative ethics: deontological and teleological. The deontological approach concerns the rightness or wrongness of a given action. The teleological approach is concerned with the goals of action in terms of goodness and badness (Rebore, 2001 p.15). I believe we know and understand the difference between right and wrong. Moreover, we know right from wrong based on our understanding of the law, and sometimes people defer to the law as the norm they must follow. These two theoretical perspectives might best be viewed as a model for what is right, wrong, good, and bad. It is reasonable to say that without a clear and thorough understanding of their own personal ethical principle, they cannot clearly determine what is right and what is wrong.

Leadership behaviors are concerned not only with ethics, personal beliefs, and values such as professionalism, attitudes, character, knowledge, skills, and actions, but also with factors in personal preference and impersonal forces in the environment (Marion, 2005). Furthermore, he/she needs to be mindful of ethical considerations, including fairness, equality, and inequality. As such, ethical behaviors are also circumstantial and depend on the situation and its contingent conditions. My decision-making is based not only on this general knowledge but also on time. My idea of a great leader is one who is trustworthy, inspires others, and practices ethics. In addition, I believe that a leader possesses the power to make a difference, and their behaviors can impact an organization and the people

who live in it. Alongside social beliefs about personal behavior, a person ought to actively practice ethical behavior in their own social life, family, workplace, community, and school. A successful person is also a champion who demonstrates fairness and equality in family, workplace, community, and school. These behavior skills mean taking responsibility, helping others, and practicing fairness and promoting justice and equity. This is an ethical attitude as it relates to behavior.

In addition, ethics and standards of conduct can be guided by how that term has been interpreted in the law. In the Encyclopedia of American School Law, there are laws covered that just about everyone might find interesting or helpful at one time or another. Schools are subject not only to these laws but also to local, state, and federal laws and judicial review (Deskbook, 2006). When applying the law, it is necessary to understand and conform to it, as well as to human values. That is equity. Furthermore, we must have self-discipline when applying ethical standards and the law. I believe that a personal standard of conduct dictates how a person applies the law in the decision-making process. Beyond right and wrong, our actions also depend on circumstances and are influenced by ethical principles, fairness, and the law.

My experience thus far has been mainly in the computer industry. Ethical behavior requires more than simply following the rules. I must understand and conform to the law and to human values. One of the things that is different from the institution is teamwork. For this reason, there is training specifically geared towards ethics—integrity, mutual respect, teamwork, communication, and

innovation. My behavior on the job and in the conduct of business is a direct reflection on the company. I am expected to apply my best judgment and seek help from the legal department in ambiguous or difficult situations, to ensure compliance with applicable laws and regulations. As a college instructor, I have a responsibility to help students understand what it is, not what it is not, according to the law and ethical norms to the best of my ability.

In conclusion, I believe that our ethical standards and behaviors are critical for every successful person (or leader), and they guide our ethical decision-making and actions, but do not dictate conduct in particular situations. Ethics can help people decide what to do when they have choices, but don't focus too much on our attitudes in an unethical direction that may eventually become so self-deceiving that we do not fully realize what we are doing (Robore, 2001, p. 33). Nevertheless, a person has a duty to act ethically and needs to be fair, reasonable, and equitable. In addition, he/she needs to be honest/open to communication, promise keeping, fair sharing of benefits, respect, and reciprocity. One of the ethical considerations worth noting is that all ethical considerations are ultimately shaped by the educational leader's understanding of what it means to be a human being and how human beings should treat one another (Rebore, 2001, p. 14). In closing thoughts, I will end with this quote: "*There is only one ethics, one set of rules of morality, one code: That of individual behavior in which the same rules apply to everyone alike.*" -Peter Drucker (1991)

References

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